

HAYS COUNTY

Hays County ends contract with Flock for license plate reader cameras

Back in February, Hays County commissioners voted to buy four more Flock cameras, but because of a clerical error, it came back up for a vote.

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HAYS COUNTY, Texas — Hays County will no longer use Flock Safety automatic license plate reader cameras (APLRs). On Tuesday, county commissioners voted to end all contracts with the security company, after facing pushback over privacy concerns.

"It's being used in ways that are so different, and that is what has caused concern in privacy, in security risks, in legal exposures," Hays County Judge Ruben Becerra said.

The county currently has six Flock cameras and [was about to buy four more](#). Back in February, commissioners voted to use \$15,000 in grant funding for the four new license plate readers.

But because of a clerical error, it went back up for a vote.

Pushback against license plate readers

In the months since, opponents have been pushing the county to get rid of the cameras all together.

"There has been plenty of time before Flock, and we just don't think that it's worth the safety and privacy and honestly violation of our rights," said Sam Benavides with the Caldwell Hays Education Fund.

Groups like the Caldwell Hays Education Fund have expressed concerns about how the data Flock cameras collect can be shared across the state and nation. They're worried about the access Immigrations and Customs Enforcement could have.

"It's not so much what our agency might do; it's what other agencies can do that we have no control over ... We know that it has been used by ICE to target immigrants. We know it has been used by Texas cops to target people seeking abortions," Benavides said.

Law enforcement support of Flock cameras

Hays County Sheriff Anthony Hipolito said it's not about surveillance, but about helping law enforcement find criminals quicker. He said the technology is something his office has successfully used for years now.

"It's something that we use every single day to help solve crimes," Hipolito said. "It's proven time and time again to be an effective tool to provide lead for our investigators and get criminals behind bars in a more efficient manner."

Hipolito said just in the past few weeks alone, law enforcement officers were able to tie the Flock data to two alleged sexual predators traveling into the county and arrest someone with a terroristic threat warrant. He worries what will happen if they don't have access to this technology anymore.

"We would be doing a disservice to every resident in this country if we didn't try to use technology to make us more efficient, stronger," Hipolito said. "It's just a loss for Hays County when we are taking technology away from law enforcement."

Other cities getting rid of APLRs

Hays County is the first county in the state to end its contract with Flock, but already, several cities have pumped the brakes. Back in June, the city of San Marcos [rejected expansion of its Flock camera fleet](#) from 14 to 33 and deactivated several of them in use.

Over the summer, the city of Austin [also got rid of automatic license plate reading cameras](#). At the time, Austin Police Chief Lisa Davis called the technology a useful tool but acknowledged the community's concerns.

What's next?

Hipolito said county leaders have talked to the sheriff's office about possibly contracting with other license plate reader camera companies, but nothing has been decided.

KVUE also reached out to Flock Safety for a comment, but we haven't heard back yet.